Past perfect and sequence of events

Goal: To use the past perfect (had + past participle) to show which of two past actions happened first, combined with the past simple and time words such as before, after and when.

The idea in two lines: In a story about an inventor, two things often happen in the past. The earlier action takes the past perfect; the later action takes the past simple.

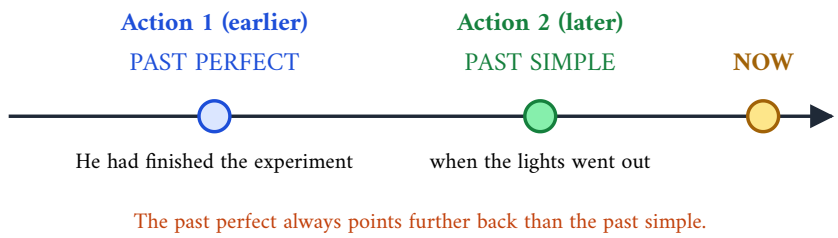


Figure 1: Two past actions on a timeline. The first one (past perfect) is completed before the second one (past simple) starts.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form:** had + past participle for all persons: I had worked, she had seen, they had gone. Negative: had not (hadn't) + past participle. Question: Had + subject + past participle?
2. **Use:** the past perfect describes an action that was already finished before another past action or before a past moment.
3. **Sequence of events:** earlier action = past perfect; later action = past simple. "Marie Curie had studied physics before she discovered radium."
4. **Time connectors:** before, after, when, as soon as, by the time, until. "By the time the doctor arrived, the patient had recovered."
5. **Already, just, never, yet** often go between had and the participle: "They had already tested the machine."

6. **Order of clauses** is free: "After he had read the article, he wrote a report" = "He wrote a report after he had read the article."

🟢 Examples

1. Put the verbs in the correct tense: "When Edison (invent) the light bulb, many scientists (already / try) to do it." **Answer:** When Edison invented the light bulb, many scientists had already tried to do it. **Explanation:** the attempts came first, so they take the past perfect.
2. Join the two sentences with "after": "Alexander Fleming noticed the mould. He returned from holiday." **Answer:** After Alexander Fleming had returned from holiday, he noticed the mould. **Explanation:** returning happened first.
3. Correct the mistake: "The inventor had received the prize last year." **Answer:** The inventor received the prize last year. **Explanation:** one past action with a finished time expression needs the past simple.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing "had + past simple" (had went, had saw) instead of **had** + **past participle** (had gone, had seen).
- Using the past perfect for both actions; only the **earlier** one takes it.
- Using the past perfect in a sentence with a single past action and a date ("In 1928 he had discovered…").
- Confusing had (past perfect) with have/has (present perfect) when the whole story is in the past.

🟡 Quick review

- Past perfect = had + past participle, same form for every subject.
- Two past actions: first one = past perfect, second one = past simple.
- Key words: before, after, when, by the time, already, just.
- One action + a date = past simple only.
- Check the irregular participle list before the exam.